

Photographs by MANEESH AGNIHOTRI



Alina
2 KG 18 months
She died due to acute malnutrition degenerating into diarrhoea and fever.

MALNUTRITION:
An area of darkness

52%*
Uttar Pradesh

43%
India

35%
Least Developing Countries

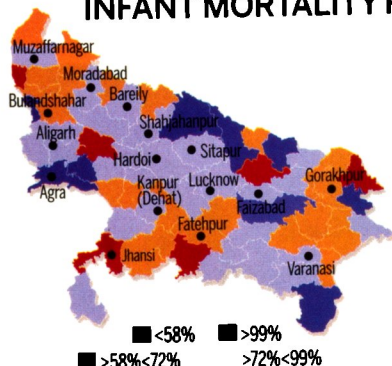
42%
South Asia

26%
Developing Countries Average

25%
World Average

Figures denote the percentage of total child population; Source: The State of Children in Uttar Pradesh prepared by the State's Planning Department & UNICEF

INFANT MORTALITY RATE IN UTTAR PRADESH



Every sixth under-nourished Indian child lives in Uttar Pradesh

Every second child in Uttar Pradesh is undernourished

Every third infant has a low birth weight i.e. below 1,200 gm

Source: The State of Children in Uttar Pradesh prepared by the State's Planning Department & UNICEF

categorised as severe), a condition that exists in places like Somalia."

Malnutrition is associated with half of the total number of child deaths and Uttar Pradesh accounts for over 10 million of India's 72 million malnourished children. Besides this, it is learnt that nearly 40 per cent of primary school dropouts have been denied mid-day meals provided by the government and other voluntary agencies. The state Government has

some tough paradoxes to deal with. Despite its 40-million-tonne foodgrain production, over 30 per cent of the state's 17-crore population barely manage to get a single meal in a day. According to the Planning Commission's 'UP Development Report', even though the state is the largest producer of foodgrain, the per capita production is lower than other states.

It's not just the numbers that are scary. Dr M.Z. Idris, head of the depart-

ment, community medicine, King George Medical College, Lucknow, adds, "Malnutrition stops total growth of the child, affecting the economic growth of the state or the country."

But these are not the only issues. The state accounts for the highest number of child abuse and child labour cases besides widespread Japanese Encephalitis (JE), mainly in Purvanchal. JE has turned out to be the biggest killer of children every year. Last year, over 467 children died and 2,226 were admitted in Gorakhpur Medical College due to JE. Yet the Government's concerns are not reflected in its actions. When JE sowed panic in the state, the state Government decided to transfer all its JE specialists. Dr Sanjay Srivastava, one of the founders of Action for Peace, Prosperity and Liberty, says he was taken aback because a court order mentions retaining JE specialists.

Clearly, Uttar Pradesh has turned into a land of threatened children. The UNICEF report should ideally be a wake-up call for the state Government. The tragedy is that for Shaheena, Sahabuddin and thousands of other children, it is already too late.